CASE STUDY

SaaS Dashboard UX Redesign

Type: Client Project

Domain: SaaS · UX Research

Status: Delivered

Client Project | SaaS · UX Research | Product Portfolio | SaaS

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Problem Framing

The client — an early-stage SaaS product — was seeing strong acquisition but poor activation. Users signed up, logged in, looked at the dashboard, and left. **Day-7 retention was below target and feature discovery was near zero.**

The brief: evaluate why users weren't activating and redesign the experience to fix it.

UX Research Approach

Heuristic Evaluation

Evaluated the existing dashboard against Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics. Key violations found:

HEURISTIC	VIOLATION
Visibility of system status	Users couldn't tell where they were in the product
Match between system and real world	Technical terminology unfamiliar to target users
Recognition rather than recall	Key features required users to remember menu locations
Aesthetic and minimalist design	Dashboard had 14 data points on the home screen — cognitive overload

Competitive Benchmarking

Analysed 5 competing SaaS products for onboarding and dashboard patterns:

- What information they showed on first login
- How they guided users to first value
- How they handled empty states
- Mobile responsiveness approach

User Flow Mapping

Mapped the existing user journey from signup to first meaningful action — identified that **most users never reached the core feature** because the navigation architecture required 3+ clicks from the home screen.

Key Insights

1. **Cognitive overload on first login.** 14 data points on the home screen meant users couldn't identify where to start. First action should be obvious, not chosen.
2. **No onboarding guidance.** Users were dropped into a full dashboard with no context. No empty state design, no guided first action.
3. **Mobile experience was an afterthought.** 60% of first-session traffic came from mobile, but the dashboard was designed desktop-first and broke on screens below 768px.

4. **Feature discovery was navigation-dependent.** Users who didn't explore the sidebar never found secondary features. Discovery needed to be embedded in the primary flow.

Redesign: 6-Screen Mobile Journey

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Screen 1: Conversational Onboarding
→ AI-driven setup: 3 questions to personalise the dashboard
→ Replaces blank dashboard on first login

Screen 2: Personalised Home
→ 3 primary actions based on onboarding responses
→ Progress tracker showing setup completion

Screen 3: Business Chat
→ AI assistant embedded in primary navigation
→ Answers product questions, surfaces relevant features

Screen 4: Feature Discovery
→ Contextual feature prompts based on user behaviour
→ Surfaces features at the right moment, not all at once

Screen 5: Progress Tracking
→ Visual milestone tracker showing value delivered
→ Reinforces activation behaviour

Screen 6: Mobile-First Navigation
→ Bottom navigation bar replacing sidebar
→ Thumb-friendly tap targets throughout
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Success Metrics Defined

METRIC	CURRENT	TARGET
Activation rate (completes onboarding)	Low	+40%
Feature discovery (uses 2+ features in session 1)	Low	+60%
Day-7 retention	Below target	+25%
Mobile session completion	Low	+50%

Key Learning

> *Activation problems are almost always information architecture problems in disguise. Users don't fail to activate because they lack motivation — they fail because they can't find the path to value.*

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